OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Questions on Shoalhaven Council's claim it cut DA times by seven weeks

Sent 16 October 2026 · To Shoalhaven City Council · Response requested by 30 October 2026

Steve Prothero
Eye on Shoalhaven Council

16 October 2026

Mr Andrew Constance
Chief Executive Officer
Shoalhaven City Council
36 Bridge Road, Nowra NSW 2541

Dear Mr Constance,

Media release of 15 October 2026: "Council beats DA targets for second year running"

I write about the figures in Council's media release of 15 October 2026 on development application (DA) assessment times.

I want to understand exactly what has been measured and how, so that what is said publicly about Council's performance is accurate.

Please answer the questions below, with the supporting data where indicated.

1. The "seven weeks" statement

1. The release says staff have "reduced DA turnaround times by seven weeks" since July 2024. What measure is this: average or median, calendar days, lodgement to determination or assessment days only? What was the starting figure, for which period, and what is the end figure, for which period?
2. Is the seven-week figure on the same basis as the Department's league table (gross calendar days from lodgement to determination, DAs only), or is it Council's own measure with adjustments such as stop-the-clock periods? If the bases differ, please give the figures on both.
3. Please provide the calculation and the document or briefing on which the statement was based.

2. The figures reported to the Department

4. What were Council's average assessment days for 2024–25 and for 2025–26 as recorded in the Department of Planning's council league table, and how many DAs were determined in each year?
5. The release says Council "also beat the target set for 2024–25". Council's release of 5 September 2025 gave that target as 110 days, and the league table shows an average of 110

days for 2024–25. By how many days did Council beat the target, and which target figure applies? The Minister's July 2026 announcement refers to a 115-day benchmark.

6. The league table reports average lodgement days (13 for Shoalhaven in 2024–25) separately from average assessment days. Which of these does the seven-week figure refer to, and what were the lodgement and assessment averages for 2025–26?

3. The mix and complexity of applications

7. For 2024–25 and 2025–26, please give for DAs determined: the number, the average days and the median days by development type (including residential alterations and additions, dwellings, second occupancies, multi-unit housing, subdivision, commercial, industrial and tourist).

8. Please also give the number of DAs lodged in each of those types in each year.

9. Has the share of simpler applications among those determined increased? What part of the reported improvement, if any, does Council attribute to a change in the mix of applications rather than faster assessment of the same kinds of applications?

4. Older and undetermined applications

10. At 30 June 2025 and at 30 June 2026, how many DAs were undetermined, and how many of those were more than 180 days and more than 365 days old? What is the age of the oldest?

11. How many DAs were withdrawn, rejected or refused in each year? Withdrawn applications are not counted in the league table averages, so please say whether Council's own reporting counts them.

5. What changed

12. The release refers to "enhanced procedures" and "higher quality DAs". What specific changes have been made since July 2024 to procedures, staffing, delegations, completeness checks at lodgement, referrals or the use of external assessors or consultants? Please also say whether any change has been made to the scope of assessment or to how applications are triaged or classified.

13. How many DAs were determined under staff delegation, and how many by Council or a planning panel, in each of the two years?

6. The grants

14. What was the exact amount of the Round 1 grant, what share of project cost does it cover, what contribution has Council committed, and what is the status of the Bernie Regan Sporting Complex and Narang Road Tennis Complex works?

15. The release says Council is eligible for a further grant "of up to $1 million". What is the basis for that figure, has Council been scored or ranked, what project will be nominated, what contribution will Council be required to make, and when will a decision be announced?

7. The current target

16. The Statement of Expectations target is now 90 days from 1 July 2026. What is Council's

average for 2026–27 to date, and what is Council's plan for meeting that target?
I ask for a written response by Friday 30 October 2026.

Yours sincerely,

Steve Prothero
Eye on Shoalhaven Council
